
A Short Case for Boring Output

Most document generators optimize for visual variety — icons, gradients, accent colors, rounded corners, illustrated divider graphics. This one does not. It generates the same kind of page, over and over, with as little chrome as possible.

Why

The point of a PDF is to be read.

- Every pixel of color is a decision the reader has to resolve.
- Every rounded corner is a style choice the reader has to accept.
- Every shadow is an attempt to imitate paper that paper itself does not need.

When those decisions aren't yours to make, the reader can just read.

What You Get

ELEMENT	TREATMENT
H1	JetBrains Mono, rule above, pure black
H2–H4	IBM Plex Sans, tight hierarchy
Body	IBM Plex Sans, 11pt, 1.55 line-height
Code	JetBrains Mono, grayscale Shiki, rules top and bottom
Tables	Uppercase mono header, no vertical borders
Links	Black, underlined — no color, no hover
Header	Title left, author right, uppercase mono, muted
Footer	[page / total] in mono, centered

How

1. Extract frontmatter with `gray-matter` .

2. Parse the Markdown to an mdast tree (`remark-parse` + `remark-gfm`).
3. Transform mdast → hast with `remark-rehype` .
4. Syntax-highlight with `@shikijs/rehype` and the grayscale theme.
5. Stringify to HTML, wrap in a minimal shell, drive Chromium headlessly.

Nothing in that list is novel. The novelty, if any, is in what's left out.

Code, For Flavor

TYPESCRIPT

```
const { content, metadata } = extractFrontmatter(raw);
const tree = parseMarkdownToMdast(content);
const html = wrapInDocumentShell(await mdastToHtml(tree), {
  title: metadata.title ?? deriveTitle(inputPath),
  baseUrl: pathToFileURL(dirname(inputPath) + "/").href,
});
```

One call per stage. No configuration surface to speak of — yet. A theme registry and plugin API will arrive when a second document format needs them, not before.

Callouts

Three types, one source format — labeled NOTE, WARN, or SYSTEM at the start of a blockquote.

NOTE

Useful context that isn't load-bearing. A quiet aside the reader can take or leave.

WARN

Something the reader must not miss. The inverted label bar is the typographic equivalent of an air-horn.

SYSTEM

A diagnostic, an engineering invariant, or a pre-condition. Dashed border reads as "from the machine, not the author."

A Note on Checklists

- ☒ ~~Use five accent colors.~~
- ☒ Use zero accent colors.
- ☒ Ship the footer with page numbers.
- ☐ Ship the cover page (Week 7).

The strikethrough, task list, and nested list all render from a single Markdown source — no special syntax, no escape hatches.

Closing

Design is a plan for arranging elements in such a way as best to accomplish a particular purpose.

— Charles Eames, who knew a thing or two about chairs.

If a boring page is readable, and a readable page gets read, the boring page has out-performed the interesting one. That is the whole case.